The King Reigns, Parliament Rules

From Magna Carta to Downing Street · English · Première and Terminale · tronc commun B1+ towards B2 (Première), B2 (Terminale) · LLCER towards C1 (C1 extensions)

Student sheet: key words, rules and homework of the eight sessions, the final task and the flashcard method. Documents, exercises and answer keys are on the website.

Session 1. Who's in charge? The King, the Prime Minister and Parliament

Key question: Who has the real power in the United Kingdom: the King, the Prime Minister or Parliament?

Today's language goal

To explain who can do what in British politics, we need modals of power (**can**, **cannot**, **has to**, **must**) and the present simple for facts.

Key words

Word	Meaning
Head of State	the person who represents the country (in the UK, the King)
constitutional monarchy	a system where the monarch's powers are limited by rules and by Parliament
impartial	not taking sides
Parliament	the place where laws are made: the House of Commons, the House of Lords and the King
MP (Member of Parliament)	a person elected to sit in the House of Commons
to appoint	to choose someone officially for a job

To say it: Modals of power

can + verb: a power or a permission. *The King can advise and warn.*

cannot (can't) + verb: something impossible or not allowed. *The King cannot give orders.*

has to / **must** + verb: an obligation. *The Prime Minister has to answer MPs' questions.* Must often shows a strong rule or the speaker's opinion.

Careful: no *to* after can and must (~~can to~~), and no *-s*: he can, he must, but he **has to**.

Homework: Learn the six key words. Then write three sentences beginning with: I think the real power belongs to ... because ...

Session 2. Runnymede, 15 June 1215: the barons against King John

Key question: Why did a king accept to put limits on his own power?

Today's language goal

To tell the story of 1215 in the right order, we need the **past simple** (regular and irregular verbs) and **time connectors** (in 1204, in May 1215, a few weeks later, finally).

Key words

Word	Meaning
baron	a powerful lord who held land from the king
charter	an official document that gives or protects rights
to seal	to close or approve a document with a wax seal
imprisoned	put in prison
the law of the land	the normal law, the same for everyone
to delay	to make something happen later

To say it: Past simple and time connectors

We use the **past simple** for finished actions at a known date: *In 1204, John lost Normandy.*

Regular verbs: **-ed** (demanded, agreed). Irregular verbs: lose / **lost**, take / **took**, set / **set**.

Negative: **did not** + verb. *King John did not sign the charter.*

Time connectors put the story in order: **in 1199**, **in May 1215**, **on 15 June**, **a few weeks later**, **then**, **finally**.

Careful: with a date, never the present perfect (~~*In 1215 he has sealed*~~).

Homework: In 80 words, explain why King John accepted to limit his own power. Use at least three verbs in the past simple.

Session 3. Magna Carta's long life: from England to the world

Key question: Why does a medieval charter still matter today?

Today's language goal

To explain how an old idea travelled through time, when the idea matters more than the people, we need the **passive voice**: be + past participle (was reissued, is still quoted).

Key words

Word	Meaning
legacy	what remains from the past and influences the present
clause	one part of a legal text
due process	the fair procedure the law must follow
to deprive of	to take something away from someone
worldwide	everywhere in the world

To say it: The passive voice

Passive = **be** (in the right tense) + **past participle**.

Past: *The charter **was reissued** in 1225.* Present: *Clause 39 **is** still **quoted** today.*

We use the passive when the action or the document matters more than who did it. Add **by** + agent only if it is useful: *The charter was declared void **by the Pope**.*

Homework: Find one recent news article or official page (parliament.uk, British Library, BBC) that mentions Magna Carta. Summarise it in five lines and copy the link.

Session 4. 1689: the Bill of Rights and the end of absolute monarchy

Key question: How did Parliament become stronger than the King?

Today's language goal

To say what the King could no longer do after 1689, and on what condition, we need **could no longer**, **without** + noun, and **unless** (= except if).

Key words

Word	Meaning
to suspend	to stop for a time
to levy money	to collect taxes
standing army	a permanent army
consent	permission, agreement
to impeach	here: to attack or question in a court
Glorious Revolution	the events of 1688 to 1689 that put William and Mary on the throne

To say it: No longer, without, unless

could no longer + verb: something that stopped. *After 1689, the King could no longer levy taxes alone.*

without + noun or -ing: *without the consent of Parliament*, *without asking Parliament*.

unless + clause = except if: *The King cannot keep an army **unless** Parliament agrees.* The Bill of Rights already says “unlesse it be with Consent of Parlyament”.

Careful: no negative after unless (~~unless Parliament doesn't agree~~).

Homework: Write a 280-character post, like on a social network, that explains what changed in 1689.

Session 5. The King reigns but does not rule

Key question: If the King has no real power, what is he for?

Today's language goal

To contrast what the King seems to do with what he really does, and argue in a debate, we need **contrast connectors** (but, whereas, while, although, however) and the present simple for general truths.

Key words

Word	Meaning
to reign	to be king or queen
to rule	to govern, to take decisions
dignified	worthy of respect, ceremonial
efficient	here: the part that really governs
Royal Assent	the monarch's formal agreement that turns a bill into an Act
a formality	something that must be done but changes nothing

To say it: Contrast

but: simple contrast in the middle. *The King reads the speech, but he does not write it.*

whereas / **while**: two facts side by side. *The Crown is dignified, whereas the Cabinet is efficient.*

although + clause: a concession. *Although the King can refuse Royal Assent, no monarch has done so since 1708.*

However, starts a new sentence, with a comma.

Homework: List three things the King does and three things he cannot do. Give one example for each.

Session 6. Parliament: the Commons and the Lords

Key question: How does a bill become a law in Westminster?

Today's language goal

To explain step by step how a bill becomes a law, and tell the story of one real Act, we need the **present passive** for a process, the **past passive** for one real case, and **ordering words** (first, then, after that, finally).

Key words

Word	Meaning
constituency	the area that elects one MP
first past the post	the voting system where the candidate with the most votes wins
bill / Act	a proposed law / a law that has been passed
reading	a stage of debate on a bill
hereditary peer	a lord whose title passes from parent to child
to delay	to make later

To say it: Present passive and past passive

A process that always works the same way: **present passive**. *A bill **is introduced** in the Commons, then it **is sent** to the Lords.*

One real case at a known date: **past passive**. *The Hereditary Peers bill **was introduced** on 5 September 2024.*

Ordering words give the order: **first**, **then**, **after that**, **finally**.

Homework: Draw or write the path of a bill in six steps, in English, with one sentence for each step.

Session 7. Number 10: the Prime Minister at the centre

Key question: How does someone become Prime Minister, and how can they lose the job?

Today's language goal

To explain the rules for becoming Prime Minister and imagine what would happen in another situation, we need **conditionals**: zero and first (if + present) for rules and likely events, second (if + past, would + verb) for imagined situations.

Key words

Word	Meaning
to appoint	to choose officially
to command the confidence of	to have the support of
majority	more than half of the seats
by-election	an election in one constituency between two general elections
to resign	to leave a job by choice
Leader of the Opposition	the leader of the second largest party in the Commons

To say it: Conditionals

Zero: a rule, always true. If + present, present. *If a party wins a majority, its leader usually becomes Prime Minister.*

First: a likely future. If + present, will + verb. *If the bill passes the Lords, it will become law.*

Second: an imagined situation. If + past, **would** + verb. *If the Government lost a vote of confidence, the Prime Minister would resign or ask the King for a general election.*

Careful: never would in the if part (~~If the Government would lose~~).

Homework: In one paragraph, explain how the UK can change Prime Minister without a general election. Use the 2026 example.

Session 8. Citizens decide: four nations, a referendum and votes at sixteen

Key question: Who has a voice in British democracy, and is the United Kingdom still united?

Today's language goal

To present election figures accurately and argue for or against votes at sixteen, we need **quantifiers and comparatives** (a majority of, more than, a narrow margin) and **should**, with a review of the passive and the second conditional.

Key words

Word	Meaning
referendum	a vote of all citizens on one question
turnout	the percentage of voters who actually vote
to leave / to remain	to go out of / to stay in
devolution	giving some powers to Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland
independence	the state of being a separate country
to register	to put your name on the list of voters

To say it: Figures, comparatives and should

Quantifiers: **a majority of**, **more than half of**, **almost two thirds of** + plural noun. *A majority of voters chose Leave.*

Comparatives: **higher than**, **lower than**, **more … than**. *The turnout was higher in 2014 (84.6%) than in 2016 (72.2%).*

should + verb for a proposal: *Sixteen-year-olds should vote.*

Review: passive (*the bill was passed by the Commons*) and second conditional (*if sixteen-year-olds voted, politicians would listen to them more*).

Homework: Prepare the plan of your final task: choose the speech or the op-ed, write your three main ideas and the three dates you will use.

Final task: From Runnymede to Westminster

Choose one format. Use at least three landmarks: 1215, 1689 and today.

Marked recap · 3 points

1. Give the dates of Magna Carta and of the Bill of Rights.

2. Who appoints the Prime Minister, and on what condition?

3. Which two nations voted Remain in 2016?

Option A. Oral (B1 to B2): a speech as a newly elected MP

You have just been elected MP. In three minutes, you explain to young voters who holds power in the United Kingdom and why their vote matters.

Step by step

1. Greet your audience and introduce yourself.
2. Explain how the King lost his power (1215, 1689).
3. Explain who governs today: Parliament, the Prime Minister, the Commons.
4. Give one recent example (2024, 2026 or 2016).
5. Conclude with a call to vote.

Option B. Written (B2 to C1): an op-ed of 250 to 300 words

For a British student newspaper: “The King reigns, Parliament rules: is British democracy still built on Magna Carta?”

Step by step

1. A title and a hook.
2. Paragraph 1: Magna Carta and its limits.
3. Paragraph 2: 1689 and the power of Parliament.
4. Paragraph 3: today, the Prime Minister, the Commons and the citizens.
5. A conclusion that answers the question with nuance.

Write your op-ed here (Option B)

Your text

0 words · target 250 to 300

Before you hand in: checklist

_____ I use at least three landmarks: 1215, 1689, today._____ I use the past simple and the passive correctly (was sealed, was passed)._____ I use modals of power: can, cannot, has to, must._____ I give one recent example (2016, 2024 or 2026)._____ My conclusion answers the question.

Assessment grid (out of 20)

Criterion	1 point	3 points	5 points
Historical accuracy	Few correct dates or confusions	Main dates and institutions correct	Accurate, precise, with a recent example
Argument and organisation	List of facts	Clear plan, links between ideas	Nuanced answer to the question, clear progression
Language	Simple sentences, frequent errors	Past simple, passive and modals mostly correct	Varied structures, precise vocabulary, few errors
Fluency (oral) or coherence (written)	Hesitant or disconnected	Mostly fluent, linking words used	Fluent and convincing, engages the audience or the reader

Each criterion is marked 1 to 5 (2 and 4 for answers between two columns). C1 extension: one bonus point for an accurate quotation (Bagehot, Roosevelt or a clause of Magna Carta) used to support an argument.

Model op-ed (B2 to C1)

Homework

Rehearse your speech twice aloud and time it, or reread your op-ed and correct it with the checklist. Hand it in at the next lesson.

My bristol flashcards · how to use them

Principle. Each student makes their own cards by hand, on bristol cards. Writing the word is already a way of learning it. The pack stays in the bag, so students can revise anywhere, with no screen. There is no ready-made deck: this page gives the method, a few model cards and a blank template.

Materials

A7 bristol cards (74 × 105 mm), about 25 per student, or A6 bristols cut in half. Felt-tip pens in four colours. An elastic band or an envelope for the pack. A small cardboard box with three compartments for practice (a shoe box with two dividers is enough). You can also print the blank template and cut it out.

What goes on a card

	What to write
Front	One English word, phrase, date or structure, in the colour of its category.
Back	A short meaning in English (a French translation only if you need it) and one example sentence of your own, linked to The King Reigns.
Corner	The category and the session where you met the item.
Check	Can I give the meaning and an example without turning the card over?

Colour code

Category	**Pen colour**
Vocabulary	green
Grammar	red
Dates and events	blue
Figures of speech and linkers	purple

When to make the cards

When	**Cards to make**
End of each first lesson of a session (lessons 1, 3, 5, 7, 9, 11, 13, 15)	Six cards: the key words of the session (homework).
Start of each second lesson (lessons 2, 4, 6, 8, 10, 12, 14, 16)	Five-minute check in pairs with the cards.

Before the mini quizzes (lessons 8 and 14)	Add the dates and the grammar rule of each session.
Lesson 17, before the final task	Finish the pack (20 cards or more), then practise in pairs with three boxes.

Practice in pairs, with three boxes

Student A shows the front; student B gives the meaning and a sentence. A card that is right moves on one box. A card that is wrong goes back to box 1. Target before the final task: 12 cards in box 3.

Model cards

Front · Vocabulary · green

Royal Assent

Back

the monarch's formal agreement that turns a bill into an Act · The King gave Royal Assent to the Hereditary Peers Act on 18 March 2026.

Front · Dates · blue

15 June 1215

Back

King John seals Magna Carta at Runnymede · In 1215 the king had to accept limits on his own power.

Front · Grammar · red

can / cannot / has to + verb

Back

no "to" after can, no -s after can · The King can warn, but he cannot give orders.

What to put on cards

Choose the items you still hesitate on. One item per card. Do not copy the whole list.

- **Vocabulary:** Head of State, impartial, to appoint, charter, to seal, the law of the land, due process, consent, standing army, to reign, to rule, dignified, efficient, Royal Assent, constituency, first past the post, hereditary peer, to command the confidence of, by-election, turnout, devolution, to register
- **Dates:** 1215, 1297, 1689, 1708, 1834, 2014, 2016, 4 July 2024, 18 March 2026, 20 July 2026
- **Grammar:** modals of power; past simple and time connectors; the passive; no longer, without, unless; contrast and concession; conditionals 0, 1 and 2; should and comparatives
- **Figures of speech and linkers:** metonymy, accumulation, antonomasia, anaphora, antithesis, metaphor, rhetorical question; whereas, although, however

Grid · my pack of cards /10

Criterion	Points
20 cards or more, with the colour code respected	/ 2
Clear handwriting, correct spelling on the front and the back	/ 3
A precise example of your own on the back (not only a translation)	/ 3
Check: the teacher draws five cards and the student answers (four right answers or more = 2 points)	/ 2

Blank template to print and cut out: PDF · Word (.docx) · LibreOffice (.odt)

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